Proposal

Wolli Creek Valley Indigenous Cultural Tours

Small group tours providing guided walks through Wolli Creek Valley and Turrella Reserve with Indigenous storytelling to showcase ancient sandstone cave paintings, medicinal plants, bush foods, and tool making.

Benefits

Protect and preserve the cave rock art in Wolli Creek.

Promote the significance of Aboriginal cultural traditions and raise public awareness through education and experience.

Training and employment of local Indigenous guides to support cultural tourism

Funding

Indigenous Business Australia (IBA) start-up package $150k (optional), includes infrastructure costs for mounted signage and protection fencing at the cave site.

Coordinator

Jessy Haiyang, a Pitjara and Iningai woman from Central QLD, with qualifications in Indigenous Cultural Tour Guiding, Horticulture and Arboriculture, Conservation and Land Management, Tree Assessment, and First Aid.

Proposed walking track

Land owners

- CBC: Canterbury-Bankstown Council
- NPW: National Parks and Wildlife
- SP2: Sewage Infrastructure

1. Tempe Station starting point
2. Saltwater marsh
3. Smoking ceremony spot
4. Start track entry point; proposed bush-regeneration site
5. Top trail entry and exit point
6. Turpentine and Angophora forest; plants of interest and tree-fern zone
7. Intersection of top and bottom trails
8. Sandstone wave-rock shelter; proposed graffiti removal and bush-regeneration site. Plant native edible and medicinal garden here and install a cultural exhibit.
9. Sydney Blue Gums; Jackson Place cottages
10. Exit point connecting to new trail; emergency exit point
11. Melaleuca forest
12. Turrella Reserve Park; drinking water; park exit to station; emergency exit point
13. Nanny Goats Hill; proposed bush-regeneration site
14. Intersection of high and low trails; plants of interest zone
15. Flying-fox colony
16. Stairs to freshwater spring well; remnant old-growth trees zone
17. Plants of interest zone and rock-climbing crag; sandstone cliff with overhang
18. Wet-season creek and small sandstone rock shelter
19. End of tour at Girrahween Park
20. Exit to Earlwood shops and public transport
21. Exit to Bardwell Station
22. Bardwell Station

Walking tour notes

Indigenous storytelling

The Bidjigal clan of the Eora Nation are the traditional owners of the Wolli Creek Valley and its surrounding wetlands. The name "Wolli" is the Dharawal word "wull'ayi," meaning "camp" and the downstream end of the creek is Goolay'yari, a Dharawal name for Pelican.

They used the area for hunting and gathering, utilising freshwater from the creek, saltwater foods from the river, and the sandstone rock caves as shelter. Hand and feet paintings that are approximately 6,500 years old can be seen with the caves at Wolli Creek Valley. Shellfish middens are scattered along the banks of the Cooks River and Wolli Creek Valley

Medicinal plants

Some medicinal plants are found in Wolli Creek Valley, including Cissus hypoglauca used to treat sore throats and Clematis glycinoides used to treat headaches. The red bark of Personia sp Geebung was also brewed as tea to treat sore throats.

Bush foods

Wolli Creek Valley was once forested with Livistonia sp, known as Cabbage Tree palms, which were edible and provided material used to make shelters, string, woven matts and hats.

Tool Making

Reeds and Grasses were used wetlands, like Wolli Creek Valley, to make light spear shafts, especially for fishing. These could be combined with hardwood sections to create composite spears. Composite spears were made by splicing different materials. The tip could be sharpened wood, or a point made from stone, bone, or shell. The tip is attached with plant resin or sap and Kangaroo or Emu leg sinew. The spear shaft was often straightened by heating over coals and bending gently.

Sandstone Ochre Wall in Wolli Creek Valley